

II The Arian Princess

Luckily, with the door now closed, the flame has returned in the burning torch, so that you can see the man again more clearly. He has come a few steps closer, which makes you back up a few, until, *ballanbilaigonds, dungenitands*, a column blocks your retreat. What is he going to do? But then, to your surprise, he bows.

—“Welcome, princess, to my abode. But you shouldn’t have come, Your Grace!” Because now, I will eat thee—well, that latter bit is just your imagination going wild. Perhaps you should nevertheless try to make it for the door, but instead you rebuke him

—“We are no princess, dear sire.”

—“Oh, but you are Your Grace, just as in my dream.”

—“You... you dreamt about me? You... saw me?”

—“As clear as daylight—well, not today’s, I guess, ha, ha,” you are too nervous to get his joke, “to collect the golden vessels that should have been given to you when you arrived. As is decreed by the laws of the *dewān* [demons].”

—“The laws of... the *dewān*?”

—“Yes, any new arrival of royal blood shall receive four golden cups and two silver plates from the *dewān*. Your Grace could have sent a page to fetch them, but I am of course deeply honored that she came to visit your humble *bandag* [slave/servant], to get the cups personally from the *dewān* [demons].” Was he now the master of the demons or was he their slave? Either way, not good!

—“From the *dewān* [demons]? Why would they want to give...”

—“Well, Your Grace, this is where we keep the golden vessels and the silverware. Here, in the *dewān*.” Something is not right! What does he mean with ‘Here, in the *dewān*’? The demons swallowed the gold and it is now in their belly? Trying to hide them?

—“Are you not the master of all *dewān*?”

—“No, just of this one. With the golden tableware. If Your Grace wants a studded diadem, she should go to the *dewān* of the Wondrous Gems.”

—“The *dewān* also have gems?”

—“Well, not this one. If you want to see, I can show you,” he points to a small trapdoor behind the table he was sitting, “There is the *dewān* with all the golden vessels.”

—“But are you not their master?”

—“Your Grace, there is only one *dewān* here, as I was trying to explain. The *dewān* of the Wondrous Gems, that is on the other side, near the *Bām-bishnān-Bāmbishn*’s quarter. I am not even allowed to go there. But Your Grace is, she is of royal blood. I understand that Your Grace is a little disappointed for only getting four golden cups, but now that you’re here, allow me to bring them up for you. It’ll just be a minute,” he points once more to the trapdoor, “they are in there.” Why does he keep referring to the *dewān* as if it was a place. Unless...

—“Dear sire, can you explain to me what *dewān* [demons] we are talking about?”

—“*Alā*, there are many, as I said. The big one is in the *House of the Hindug*, that is where they keep all the books. Those we call the Archives of the *Chroniclers*. And there is a *dewān* for the armor—that is in the citadel—and for foodstuffs—that is in the kitchens...”

—“So, these *dewān*... they are not *dew* [demon]?”

—“What do you mean *dew*? Oooh, I see, you thought I meant *dewān*, as in many *dew* [demon]. Ha, ha. No, no. These *dewān* [divan/archive] are just places where we keep stuff. I never thought of that, why do they call it *dewān* then. I guess, to scare off trespassers, ha, ha.” His laughing would put you a little more at ease, if it were not that shrill and at the same time breathy. But at least, no demons are dragging you off. Yet! But that leaves his misunderstanding about who you are. He must have you confused with Mariam, on account of your hair: Mariam and you, the only two red-haired ones in the palace, and perhaps even in the entire capital.

—“*Abaḡshāyid* [sorry]. I apologize for my mistake and my ... awkward reaction. But I must correct you, dear sire, I insist: I am not a princess. You must have me confused with princess Mariam, the Emperor’s niece. While also Goth, I am only her handmaiden. But I will be glad to collect the golden vessels for her. She will be pleased.”

—“Princess Mariam? You mean the *Hromāyig* [Roman] princess? No, no. She already got her share.” So, that’s where those golden chalices came from. You always thought that Mariam had brought them with her. But you should have known better that that was Persian craftsmanship. The rows of ever smaller circles, in alternating bright red and white colors, separated by little green glass squares, with beautiful rosettes drawn in the middle of each circle. That’s not Roman art! But whom then has he you confused with? Or, more to point, what is his plan with whoever he thinks you are? You’d better get out of here before your Gothic tale ends

here and now!

—“For which my mistress is eternally grateful. They are so elegant. So, it seems that that matter is cleared up then. It was all a big misunderstanding, ha, ha,” you start shuffling back towards the door, “*alā*, I think the rain has calmed down a bit. So, dear sire, many times *spās* [thanks], but I’d better be on my way then.” On cue, to once more make their angry presence clear, the weather gods—exhaling so-to-speak a big gust of wind—make the door swing open with a bang, the sound of which is partly drowned by an even deeper rumble of a nearby thunder. Outside, the torrential rain has now made it virtually pitch black, its darkness only more accentuated by an occasional lightning flash. So, you have no choice but to turn around again—you are doomed!—, as the master of the *dewān* tries to argue with you.

—“But you are the Arian princess, are you not?” Does he mean Arian, like in the teachings of the heretic Areios?

—“Oh, no. Although now an orphan, my mother already recanted the faith of my people before I was born.”

—“Oh, that’s bad. Why would your mother recant the fate of her people? What about your father? He surely was Arian!” Truthfully, you never asked mommy whether daddy also had converted before he died on the battlefield.

—“I am not sure. But you have me confused with someone else, good sire.”

—“My dream never lies, Your Grace,” it sounds like that he must have seen you before and then has spun this romantic tale of you being his Arian princess? You have done similar things, so you cannot really be angry with him, although it is a little creepy. He is at least twice your age, “Let Lord TIR be my witness.” The gods seemed to be listening, for just then, another thunderbolt lights the doorway. You are familiar enough with the Persian pantheon to know that TIR is their god of rain. And apparently also of dreams? But then, to your horror, the white contour of the doorway is blocked by the silhouette of a second figure! This time, the true demon has arrived?

—“You cretin, what nonsense are you spouting again! And who is that filly?” It’s a demoness? You can hear him mumble between his teeth

—“Of course, the witch is drunk again,” but then out loud, he replies, “Mother, this is a princess of Erān, show some respect.” Oh, that’s what he meant with Aryan! Like meaning from Erān, which is their word for

Persia! Shows you how wrong he is! The older woman—apparently his mother—which still does not exclude her from being a demoness—has now come inside, so that you can see her face. Apart from soaking wet, she does look quite inebriated, as she sways around the column that is still blocking your escape.

—“Well, *doshag* [dear], I wouldn’t put too much stock in my son’s words. Mad as a dog in heat,” she puts her hand on your shoulder, which makes you shudder—after all, she is drunk and she might very well be a witch, “I apologize, sweetheart. He gets his delusions from his fathers’ side, those accursed *dewān*!” She spits on the ground, while making a deep gurgling sound. So, he was half demon now, and mad? Well, the latter, you are also more and more getting convinced of. But that doesn’t really improve your situation, for the mother is now completely blocking your egress.

—“I apologize, Your Grace, let me quickly fetch the golden vessels so that you can be on your way.” As he is saying that, he opens the trapdoor to the *dewān*. He is going to leave you alone with the witch? Which of the two evils is the worse? So, in panic, you choose him—after all, he thinks of you as a princess, so, he probably will behave accordingly.

—“On second thought, dear sire, I will take you up on your offer to see the treasures of the *dewān* with my own eyes.” That actually pleases him. And so, with a broad smile, he invites you to descend down the stairs, following you with a torch. The stairs actually twist down to what looks—well, rather sounds, for it is dark as hell in here—quite a large space. Just as you reach the bottom and can see some silver and golden trinkets shining in the light of the torch, you hear a voice from above. His mother’s head appears above the open trapdoor.

—“Say, dear son of mine, you wouldn’t happen to have a jar of wine in there.”

—“Mother!”

—“To drown your mother’s sorrows! What else ... does ... does she have?” That last bit she mumbles more than speaks, and you see her sway forward, leaning heavily on the trapdoor. The hinges do not allow the door to open more than half way, and now, she is dangerously close to have it fall With a loud bammm!, that’s exactly what happens!

—“Mother!!” In the panic to try running back up the stairs, he drops the torch. In the pitch dark, you hear him grunt.

—“Sire, what... what...?” The blackness seems to stifle your words...

—“Mother!! Mother!!!,” he bangs on the door, “By OHRMAZD and the

seven AMAHRASPAND, she has fallen on top of it! Why is she not answering?" ... , and your thoughts. This then is how your Gothic tale ends: in the bowels of the *dewān*, swallowed by gold-eating demons, for ever to remain hidden from humanity!